THE BIG GAINS

- More than 1.2 million citizens have so far availed contactless services without visiting the DTO offices.
- 200 per cent increase in the number of issuance of learners' licence between September 3, 2021, and September 3, 2022.
- More than 3.6 million man-days have been saved due to the introduction of contactless services.
- The saving of man-days is estimated to generate economic benefit of around Rs 180 crore.

vehicle on sale or death of the owner), hypothecation cancellation, hypothecation endorsement, NOC for inter-district and inter-state transfer of vehicle from one DTO to another, change of address (of vehicle owners after taking NOC from one DTO to another), duplicate registration certificate (in case of loss, torn, mutilated)—and four Sarathi-software based services—driving license, international driving permit (to authorize Indian driving license holder to drive in another country), replacement of driving license (in case of torn or mutilated driving license), surrender of class of vehicle and driving licence extract (in case required by any agencies like the insurance investigators).

The Assam government also introduced the CM – Transport Randomised Allocation Networked System (CM-Trans) in the transport department. It is, in fact, the most unique digital initiative of Assam government. This pioneering initiative ushers in a mechanism, which not only provides online application and disposal facilities to citizens but also uniformly distributes workload among all DTOs to increase the speed and efficiency of service deliverance. A brainchild of Chief Minister Sarma, it's the first such system launched in any state of India.

The new system, launched on May 13, 2022, does away with the concept of verification and approval of applications in the same DTO where it has been submitted. Instead, it randomly allocates an application to any of the 32 DTOs of Assam based on their individual workload. The application is automatically routed to the DTOs where the pendency is comparatively less. This uniform distribution of work ensures greater efficiency and faster delivery. The applicant and the DTO, in which he or she submitted the application, do not get to know which DTO has been allocated the responsibility of processing the application. This ensures complete elimination of the role of the middle men and unnecessary harassment of applicants. “The DTOs should have less burden so that they can focus solely on enforcement of rules and regulations. By gradually phasing out offline application and service delivery, the DTOs would be made free to work in enforcement,” says Chief Minister Sarma.

The transport department has also taken several other digital initiatives—14,500 Common Service Centres (CSC) for 40 online and contactless transport services to citizens, e-challan in all districts, online approval for vehicle scrapping and mVahan, a mobile-based app for fitness inspection and approval of commercial vehicles. As expected, this innovative system resulted in greater efficiency, transparency, and faster service delivery.

Thanks to the paradigm shift in service delivery mechanism, there has been an overwhelming public response to these contactless services. More than 1.2 million citizens have so far availed contactless services without visiting the DTOs. There is instance of 200 per cent increase in the number of issuance of learners' licence in just one year—between September 3, 2021, and September 3, 2022. It is estimated that more than 3.6 million man-days have been saved due to the introduction of such contactless services, which results in huge economic benefit to the state. The saving of man-days is estimated to generate economic benefit of around Rs 180 crore (at minimum wage for skilled workforce), a massive amount for a north-eastern state.

Nearly 400,000-500,000 people visit DTOs for the purpose of registration of new vehicles. To reduce this footfall at DTOs and to ensure ease of registration, not just dealer-point registration facility was implemented, but the automobile dealers were also empowered with the power of registering authority. Thus, Assam became the first state in the country to implement dealer point registration by empowering the automobile dealers with the power of registering authority for both in-built commercial and personalised vehicles. The dealers are also empowered to print registration certificates (RCs) so that there is no requirement to visit DTOs at all and the RCs can be printed and delivered to public at the dealer-point itself.

The contactless services also helped in pushing digital transactions in the state. Since September 1, 2020, the transport department has officially stopped collection of all motor vehicle taxes/fees in cash at all DTOs. All revenue receipts by the department since then have been issued online only. This endeavour of the transport department has resulted in generation of a total revenue of Rs 2,382 crore in the digital mode between September 1, 2020, and November 30, 2022. Through the use of technology, the scope for revenue leakage has also been considerably reduced.

The government did not stop at launching these services, but also ensured accessibility and availability of these services in every nook and

